

Chapter 34-1: Close Person

She could only see her profile, pressed close against the stone table, tears gathering in one place before dropping onto the table with a patter.

Ning Fuyi couldn't distinguish where she was, couldn't even distinguish her own name, but this scene crashed thunderously into her mind with an unprecedented sense of familiarity.

It was as if the same tears had appeared before her eyes thousands of years ago.

"Don't hurt her," someone said to her, from the void, from beyond the years.

Don't hurt her. Ning Fuyi suddenly sprang back, her head splitting with pain like it was being torn apart. She staggered backward and hit the wall again. The paintings hanging on the wall clattered to the ground, several candles were knocked over, and the room flickered between light and shadow.

Chu Qingqiu felt the loosening of the force upon her. She suddenly stood up, gazing at Ning Fuyi through tear-blurred vision.

"Ning Fuyi," she said, her hands trembling.

But the young woman seemed unable to hear her at all. She only felt ice and fire alternating within her body, as if three forces were pulling at her heart and lungs - one burning her insides, making her body burn with desire; another devouring her mind, making her lose all reason and become violent.

And there was a third one, the weakest yet never disappearing - that voice in her mind.

Don't hurt her.

Chu Qingqiu dragged her unsteady steps forward one by one. Just as she approached Ning Fuyi, she was suddenly pulled by the arm again. The two figures spun in a circle, and before Chu Qingqiu could react, Ning Fuyi had already stood on her tiptoes, and their lips touched.

Chu Qingqiu immediately widened her eyes, the swaying lamplight making her dizzy.

Then came a stinging pain. Ning Fuyi had somehow bitten through her lip, and the sweet metallic taste of blood permeated their lungs through their breath.

Before Chu Qingqiu could raise her hand, the young woman suddenly moved away again. She extended her hand, and White Bone on the ground suddenly sprang up, carrying a fierce wind, instantly striking toward her own head.

There was a clang as White Bone rolled away, and Ning Fuyi also fell softly, her black robes piled on the ground, covering her slender body.

The room fell silent. Chu Qingqiu's body suddenly slumped, falling to sit on the ground, her delicate fingers wiping across her lips, staining her hand with shocking red.

After a long while, she finally spoke hoarsely: "Bai Lin."

As soon as the words fell, Bai Lin leaped in through the window, landing lightly. Obviously startled by the chaotic scene in the room, it then went to nuzzle Ning Fuyi with its head.

"Drag her over here." She had no strength left and could only watch as Bai Lin bit Ning Fuyi's leg and dragged her to her side.

Chu Qingqiu silently placed her fingertips on Ning Fuyi's wrist, feeling her pulse, then suddenly cut her own palm. Bright red blood dripped out drop by drop, falling onto Ning Fuyi's lips.

The unconscious Ning Fuyi seemed to taste this sweetness and extended her pink tongue to take the blood into her mouth.

She didn't know how long the blood dripped until Chu Qingqiu's vision darkened and she nearly collapsed against the wall. Only then did she lower her hand and breathe lightly.

"Send her back, and be sure not to disturb anyone." Chu Qingqiu said weakly. Bai Lin obediently expanded to human size, carried Ning Fuyi on its back, and disappeared outside the window.

Only Chu Qingqiu remained in the room. She silently lay down slowly, her eyes full of mockery and a confusion never shown to others.

Chu Qingqiu, oh Chu Qingqiu, you're still harboring fantasies. You've already made one mistake and nearly made a second.

Truly unforgivable.

The morning at Zhaoyang Mountain came earlier than at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. The moment the azure phoenixes sang in unison, the eastern sky burst with rosy light, and the first ray of sunrise crossed over the continuous divine mountains, illuminating the sky full of auspicious clouds with brilliant red light.

Countless rare birds took flight from the mountain forests, gathering in mid-air regardless of species, passing through the fire-like auspicious clouds and displaying their songs in the sky. This was a magnificent sight that could only be seen at Zhaoyang Mountain - a hundred birds greeting the sun.

The area where the divine site was located overflowed with spiritual energy, making people feel relaxed and fall into peaceful sleep. Therefore, even this bird song didn't wake the sleeping crowd, and the pavilions remained quiet.

In the morning's rosy light, a white figure transformed into flowing light, shuttling through the blooming peach blossom forest, silently landing on a roof eave. The breeze lifted her garments, her figure like a solitary, proud crane, her eyes showing neither joy nor anger.

Peach blossom petals brushed past her nose. She turned her head to avoid them and reached out to remove White Bone, spinning it once in her hand. The entire pavilion beneath her feet was sealed with a barrier, no longer revealing the slightest breath.

She silently dropped into the corridor, her shoe soles clean and dust-free, walking slowly along the corridor.

"Who goes there..." A passing immortal attendant was about to scold her when he suddenly recognized who she was and hurriedly bowed. However, Chu Qingqiu paid no attention, only focused on passing through the crowd, following the scent to enter the door.

Clang - the door closed and locked.

"Who dares intrude into our Hehuan Sect! Chu Ling Divine Venerable?" The visitor was an older woman. Upon seeing Chu Qingqiu, her expression immediately changed. The tea and snacks in her hands clattered to the ground. She quickly put on a smile: "I didn't know the Divine Venerable was gracing us with her presence. I failed to welcome you properly. I'll go right away..."

"Was it you yesterday?" Chu Qingqiu spoke, her voice clear and light, betraying no emotion.

The woman swallowed her words. Her expression changed like shifting clouds, finally squeezing out a smile: "What does the Divine Venerable mean? I, I don't understand."

"How convenient that you don't understand." Chu Qingqiu stepped toward her, her red lips slightly parted: "Peach Blossom Lady¹ of the Hehuan Sect, wherever she walks, there is the scent of peach blossoms."

"This, this Peach Blossom Garden is full of peach blossoms everywhere. How can you say it's me?" The woman picked up things from the ground, laughing awkwardly.

"Oh?" Chu Qingqiu had turned her back to her but suddenly turned around, her dark brows moving slightly: "When did I ever say the incident happened in the Peach Blossom Garden?"

The woman froze.

Before she could open her mouth to explain again, White Bone in Chu Qingqiu's hand suddenly flew out, transforming into a white shadow that struck the woman's chest. The woman immediately spat out blood, her body flying up and falling, smashing the flowers arranged in the room to pieces.

She cried for help while crawling up from the mess, her face and body covered with petals and mud, looking extremely disheveled: "Divine Venerable, I don't know what you're talking about. Someone help! Help!"

Just as she finished shouting, Chu Qingqiu's shadow suddenly enveloped her. The woman opened her eyes wide in terror, watching as Chu Qingqiu extended her palm toward her.

A blinding white light flashed, and the woman let out a piercing scream, throwing her head back and falling again.

Chu Qingqiu seemed not to hear her scream, her gaze not stopping on her for a moment as she turned and walked into the inner room.

She immediately encountered Li Hanyan, who had tried to escape several times but was blocked back by the barrier.

Li Hanyan looked at the entering Chu Qingqiu and stood frozen in place, smiling awkwardly. She reached out to smooth the wrinkles in her dress and sat down gracefully, her slender legs exposed, speaking softly and slowly: "Divine Venerable comes so suddenly. What brings you here?"

"Her cultivation, I have already destroyed it." Chu Qingqiu didn't engage with her words but continued speaking to herself: "Cultivating immortal arts is meant to punish demons and eliminate evil, to protect all living beings, not to use one's cultivation to harm others."

"Useless immortals might as well not cultivate at all."

Li Hanyan's expression stiffened for a moment, then was covered with a smile again: "The Divine Venerable is right. I will educate all the people in my sect."

"Divine Venerable..."

Her words were cut short abruptly. Chu Qingqiu had somehow appeared in front of her, White Bone flashing with cold light, striking toward her throat. Li Hanyan immediately leaned back, her body suddenly flying up, her water sleeves transforming into colorful whips that wrapped around White Bone.

White Bone suddenly stirred up a fierce wind, overturning all the furnishings in the room while also shredding the whips. Li Hanyan, seeing the situation was bad, quickly flew up to stand on the roof beam. The whips restored themselves to perfect condition, and White Bone also flew back to Chu Qingqiu's palm.

"Don't just talk about her. What about you?" Chu Qingqiu stood in place and spoke.

Li Hanyan's beautiful face showed a moment of collapse. After a long while, she stroked her whip with her delicate hand and said softly: "Divine Venerable, I was wrong. I will never dare again. Everything I did had no intention of harming others. It's just that ever since that day at East Huang Ridge, when you spoke up for me and wouldn't let those self-proclaimed righteous people bully me for practicing unorthodox methods, I could never forget the Divine Venerable."

"I still remember that day when many high-cultivation scattered immortals knew I was a disciple of the Hehuan Sect, more than ten people together persecuted me. It was you who stood out to protect me behind you, dispersing those hypocritical people with just a few words." Li Hanyan put away the usual smile on her face: "Since then, I've hoped to see the Divine Venerable again. However, I've run to Purple Cloud Peak many times but couldn't get an audience. Now that I finally have a chance to meet you, I couldn't help but act so desperately..."

"I spoke for you because I don't believe immortal arts have high or low status. As long as one doesn't do bad things, one shouldn't be bullied." Chu Qingqiu looked at her with no trace of pity in her eyes: "I didn't think what you practiced was unorthodox, but now you use charm arts against me. If I had known this would happen, why would I have helped you that day!"

Li Hanyan trembled at her words, shaking her head repeatedly: "Divine Venerable, I didn't really want to harm you. I just wanted to make you fall in love with me. But yesterday, before I could act, you discovered me, so I didn't dare show myself again."

"And if the Divine Venerable was unwilling, I would definitely help you break the charm art and would never..."

"I will never fall in love with anyone." Chu Qingqiu interrupted her words, her profile so beautiful it was startling: "Especially not someone as despicable as you."

Li Hanyan stood frozen in place.

"As a sect leader, to do such shameful things!" Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice, then spread her arms. Several white silk ribbons surged out with the wind. Li Hanyan quickly waved her sleeves, and countless spirit butterflies poured out from her sleeves to block the silk ribbons, but knowing she was in the wrong, she didn't fight back.

For a moment, the room was like a great wind passing through, rolling up almost everything until even the walls seemed about to be overturned. In a dizzying moment, White Bone suddenly soared up and struck her squarely in the chest. Li Hanyan groaned softly, her body suddenly flying down from the roof beam, staggering as she landed.

She spat out blood.

The great wind dispersed, and not a single intact place remained in the pavilion. Li Hanyan swayed twice and sat back on the couch with a thud, covering her chest and panting, her eyes sorrowful, not daring to speak further.

"You should be glad you didn't actually hurt anyone, or I would disregard the relationship between the six sects and demand your life." Chu Qingqiu's expression didn't change; she only said in a low voice.

"Don't mention this to anyone, and from now on, don't come near me again." After saying this, she strode away, not letting Li Hanyan see her momentarily pale complexion.

The white figure disappeared into the flower forest. The barrier was removed, the roof instantly collapsed, and amidst the terrified screams, faint crying could be heard from within the room.

Ceaselessly sorrowful.

Ning Fuyi was unaware of these disturbances. When she opened her eyes, she was nearly knocked unconscious again by the severe pain in her head.

It was as if her brain had been torn apart by several people all night long. The pain made her vision dizzy, and various dream scenes kept appearing before her eyes. Those scenes were very strange, making her face flush and heart race, but she couldn't see the other person's face clearly.

She only remembered that the person seemed to be crying constantly, crying until she was covered in tears.

How was she in the room? What had happened last night? Ning Fuyi covered her head and sat up, slowly recalling. She only remembered going to Chu Qingqiu's place to warn her and incidentally helping her destroy the spirit butterfly that spread charm arts.

She just hadn't expected the Hehuan Sect's spells to be so sophisticated, actually carving charm arts onto the butterfly's wings. Besides being touched or smelled, even seeing them would cause one to fall for the trick, and with her low cultivation, she couldn't guard against it.

No wonder that Li Hanyan had such confidence, daring to use this method on Chu Qingqiu.

So she herself had... Ning Fuyi cursed something and looked down at herself. She was still wearing the same clothes from yesterday, with quite a bit of dirt on them. Several fingernails were cracked, and her fingertips had many abrasions, still bearing blood scabs.

She lifted her collar to look inside and sighed in relief. Her clothes hadn't been disturbed, so Chu Qingqiu must have helped her break the charm art without letting her act improperly.

Fortunately. Ning Fuyi lowered her hand, but she wondered if she had made a fool of herself last night. If she had done something embarrassing, wouldn't Chu Qingqiu have seen it all and laughed at her?

Only that Emei Thorn that should have been within reach had missed this good opportunity. Now that the Zhaoyang Saintess would come out of seclusion today, it would be difficult for her to enter Shenyu.

Never mind, never mind. As long as she was still at Zhaoyang Mountain, there would always be opportunities. Ning Fuyi sighed heavily, slowly got up, circulated her energy to smooth the pain in her head, and took out some spirit medicine from her pouch to apply to herself, letting the wounds on her hands heal smoothly.

Footnotes:

1. **Peach Blossom Lady (桃花夫人)** - A title referring to a woman from the Hehuan Sect, likely indicating her specialty in seduction and charm arts, with "peach blossom" being associated with romantic affairs in Chinese culture